

QA & Engineering Glossary

Quick reference for acronyms and technical terms used across the quality ecosystem.

QA - Quality Assurance

Practices used to prevent problems and increase confidence in product and process quality throughout development.

Quality Engineering

Engineering approach that embeds quality, testability, automation, observability and continuous feedback into delivery.

Bug / Defect

Behavior that differs from an expectation, requirement or business rule. A useful report includes environment, steps, data, actual and expected results, and evidence.

Error

Incorrect human action or decision that may introduce a defect.

Failure

Observable manifestation of a problem while the system is running.

Test Scenario

High-level situation or flow to validate; it can lead to multiple test cases.

Test Case

Documented preconditions, data, steps and expected results used to verify a specific behavior.

Test Suite

Organized collection of related test cases.

Test Plan

Plan describing scope, approach, resources, environments, risks and test criteria.

Test Strategy

High-level guidance for how quality will be approached.

Severity

Impact caused by a defect.

Priority

Relative urgency for addressing an item.

Regression Testing

Testing that checks whether recent changes caused unwanted effects in existing behavior.

Smoke Testing

Small set of critical checks used to quickly assess build stability.

Sanity Testing

Focused validation of a specific change or fix.

Exploratory Testing

Approach where learning, test design and execution happen together.

UAT

User Acceptance Testing: validation from the business or representative-user perspective.

Flaky Test

Test that alternates between pass and fail without a corresponding product change.

API

Interface that lets systems or components exchange data and perform operations in a structured way.

Endpoint

Address representing an API resource or operation.

Request

Call sent to a service, including method, URL, headers, parameters and possibly a body.

Response

Service reply containing status, headers and possibly a payload.

Payload

Data carried in a request or response body.

HTTP Status Code

Code summarizing an HTTP result; validate it together with content and business rules.

Mock

Controlled substitute for a real dependency.

Stub

Simplified implementation that returns predefined responses.

Fixture

Reusable state, data or resource setup for tests.

Locator

Strategy used by automation to find a UI element.

Assertion

Automated verification of an expected condition.

CI - Continuous Integration

Frequent integration of changes with automated build and checks.

Continuous Delivery

Practice of keeping software releasable through automated build, tests and delivery preparation.

Continuous Deployment

Automatic production deployment of changes approved by the automated flow.

Pipeline

Automated flow of build, tests, analysis, packaging and deployment.

Artifact

File or package produced by a build, test or pipeline.

Observability

Ability to understand internal system state through logs, metrics and traces.

Lead Time

Time between request and delivery of an item.

Cycle Time

Time between actual work start and completion.

WIP

Work in Progress: amount of work being handled simultaneously.

Sprint Goal

Single Sprint objective that guides the work.

Definition of Done

Shared quality criteria required for an Increment to be considered done.

RTM

Requirements Traceability Matrix linking requirements, tests, executions and defects.

Boundary Value Analysis

Technique focused on boundaries and values immediately below and above them.

Equivalence Partitioning

Technique that divides data into classes expected to behave equivalently.

Test Data

Prepared data for valid, invalid, boundary and relevant-combination scenarios.

Testability

Property that makes a system easier to control, observe and diagnose during testing.

SQL

Language used to query and manipulate relational data; QA uses it to validate persistence, rules and consistency.

Data Quality

Quality of data across dimensions such as completeness, validity, consistency, uniqueness and timeliness.

OWASP

Community and widely used application-security resources, including risk references and testing practices.

Load Testing

Performance testing that evaluates system behavior under an expected or defined workload.

Stress Testing

Testing that pushes load beyond normal conditions to observe limits, degradation and recovery.

WCAG

Web Content Accessibility Guidelines: international recommendations for making web content more accessible.

Accessibility Testing

Validation of access barriers for people with different needs, combining tools and human evaluation.